SEEDS & SEED STARTING

Seed-starting chart

MY LAST FROST DATE _____

When to start 18 popular crops indoors, counted from your average last spring frost.

Crop	Start indoors	Plant out	Or sow outside	My sow date	My plant-out date
Onions, from seed Takes frost	10–12 wks before	2–4 wks before	—		
Leeks Takes frost	10–12 wks before	Up to 2 wks before	—		
Peppers, hot Frost-tender	8–10 wks before	2–3 wks after	—		
Parsley Takes frost	8–10 wks before	2–3 wks before	2–4 wks before		
Peppers, sweet Frost-tender	7–9 wks before	2–3 wks after	—		
Eggplant Frost-tender	7–9 wks before	2–3 wks after	—		
Tomatoes Frost-tender	6–8 wks before	1–2 wks after	—		
Broccoli Light frost OK	6–8 wks before	2–3 wks before	—		
Cabbage Takes frost	6–8 wks before	2–4 wks before	—		
Cauliflower Light frost OK	6–8 wks before	1–3 wks before	—		
Brussels sprouts Takes frost	6–8 wks before	Up to 2 wks before	—		
Kale Takes frost	6–8 wks before	2–4 wks before	4–6 wks before		
Lettuce, head Light frost OK	6–8 wks before	2–4 wks before	—		
Basil Frost-tender	4–6 wks before	1–2 wks after	2–4 wks after		
Cucumbers Frost-tender	2–3 wks before	1–2 wks after	Up to 2 wks after		
Squash, summer Frost-tender	2–3 wks before	1–2 wks after	Up to 2 wks after		
Pumpkins Frost-tender	2–3 wks before	1–2 wks after	1–2 wks after		
Melons Frost-tender	2–3 wks before	1–2 wks after	1–2 wks after		

Example: last frost Apr 20

Crop	Sow indoors	Plant out
Onions	Jan 26 – Feb 9	Mar 23 – Apr 6
Sweet peppers	Feb 16 – Mar 2	May 4–May 11
Tomatoes	Feb 23 – Mar 9	Apr 27 – May 4
Cucumbers	Mar 30 – Apr 6	Apr 27 – May 4

- Find your own average last frost date: your local extension service lists it.
- Harden seedlings off outdoors for 7–10 days before planting out.
- Plant frost-tender crops out only once frost has passed and the soil is warm.

Approximate ranges from University of Minnesota, NDSU and Cornell Extension guidance and the Farmers' Almanac seed-starting guide, in our own words. Check your seed packet and local advice. "Up to 2 wks" = between the frost date and 2 weeks before or after it.